

C1 ■ ALIGN Health Matters

I care. You count. We matter.

**SPECIAL
EDITION**

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Why health matters

Respiratory risks

HAVs

Musculoskeletal disorders



What 3 things

3 things everyone needs to do:

Construction work can take a toll on your health if the basics are overlooked.



Protect your lungs – always wear RPE - fit it properly, keep it clean.



Guard Against Vibration – Use low-vibration tools, making sure they are regularly maintained, regular breaks, report tingling or numbness in your hands early. HAVS is preventable but permanent if ignored.



Lift Smart – Plan the lift, use mechanical aids when possible, never lift more than you can handle. Good technique protects your back for life

aim
high

SLAM

Submit an
observation -
good or needs
improvement



Why Health Matters in Construction

In the construction industry, health risks are often less visible than safety hazards—but their impact is far greater and longer-lasting. Every year in the UK, around 13,000 people die from occupational diseases caused by workplace exposures. That's the equivalent of a full stadium of rugby fans at Cardiff Arms Park or the whole population of Chorleywood.

The Hidden Dangers on Site

Construction workers face a wide range of health risks, including:

- Dust and Chemical exposures
- Noise and vibration
- Manual handling injuries

These risks contribute to thousands of new cases of occupational illness each year, including noise-induced hearing loss, hand-arm vibration syndrome (HAVS), and musculoskeletal disorders (MSDs). The construction sector also bears the largest burden of occupational cancer, with over 5,000 new cases annually.

The Cost of Inaction

Failing to manage health risks doesn't just harm workers—it affects the entire business. In 2023, the UK construction sector lost 2.6 million working days, with 80% due to work-related illness. The consequences are:

- **Human** – Real people suffer, often with long-term or irreversible conditions.
- **Financial** – Lost productivity, higher insurance costs, and potential HSE fines.
- **Reputational** – Public enforcement actions can damage trust and credibility.

Changing the Culture

Health is often seen as "too difficult" to manage—its effects are delayed, and solutions aren't always obvious. But the truth is: ill-health can be prevented. Just like safety, health risks can be assessed, controlled, and reviewed. Everyone on site has a role to play.

 **Think Health Like Safety:** Look after your body like you look after your boots—protect it now or pay for it later.

 **Stop the Risk at the Source:** Don't wait for symptoms. If there's dust, noise, or vibration—sort it. Speak up. Get it fixed.

 **Fix the Job, Stay Fit for Life:** It's not about changing you—it's about changing the way the job is done. When risks are controlled properly, you can finish the job in the same good health you started it.

Respiratory Risk- Construction Dust

Respiratory health is a major concern in the UK construction industry, where workers are regularly exposed to airborne hazards. One of the most significant risks at South Portal currently is demolition dust, which can contain harmful substances such as silica and other fine particulates.

Why Demolition Dust Is Dangerous

Demolition activities generate large volumes of **respirable dust**—tiny particles, invisible to the naked eye to enter the lungs. Of particular concern is **respirable crystalline silica (RCS)**, commonly released when materials like concrete, brick, and stone are broken apart. Prolonged exposure to RCS can lead to serious diseases, including:

- **Silicosis** – a progressive, incurable lung disease
- **Chronic Obstructive Pulmonary Disease (COPD)**
- **Lung cancer**

Even short-term, high-intensity exposure can pose severe health risks, especially without proper controls.



1. Know the Main Respiratory Hazards

Common airborne hazards on UK construction sites include:

- Silica dust
- Asbestos fibres
- Wood dust
- Welding fumes
- Diesel exhaust emissions

2. Use the Hierarchy of Control

- Follow the HSE's hierarchy of risk control:
- Eliminate the hazard (e.g., use pre-cut materials)
- Reduce exposure (e.g., wet cutting to suppress dust)
- Isolate the hazard (e.g., work in well-ventilated areas)
- Control exposure (e.g., use local exhaust ventilation)
- PPE (use RPE only as a last resort or in combination)

3. Use Proper Respiratory Protective Equipment (RPE)

- Always wear suitable, face-fit tested RPE
- Use the right filter
- Make sure RPE is cleaned and maintained regularly
- Replace filters as per manufacturer guidance

4. Health Surveillance

Report early symptoms like coughing, wheezing, or breathlessness

5. Get Trained

Ensure you are trained on:

- How to use RPE correctly
- Dust control techniques
- Identifying and avoiding asbestos

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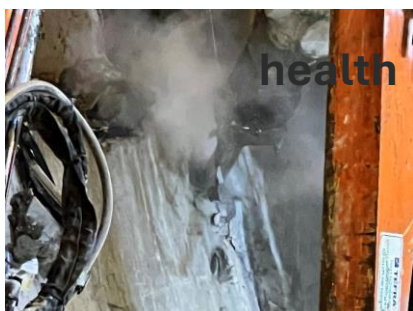
Other common sources of dust on site:



Drilling into concrete is often seen as being a quick activity, but as you can see here it can produce a lot of dust.



Grinding or buffing concrete, even when using a vacuum, can produce clouds of silica dust, especially if the pad is not fully on the flat.



Breaking concrete produces high dust levels that, even with wetting down, are not completely removed.



Scabbling produces significant levels of dust and is difficult to control with vacuums.



Sweeping up dust produces significant levels that stay in the air for a long time.



Cutting or sanding wood produces significant levels of dust that are difficult to control.

**Protect your lungs, use controls and wear your mask.
Every breath counts, don't take risks with your health.**

Work Smarter, Move Better: Plant Ergonomics

Ergonomics is about designing the workplace to suit the worker. For plant operators, this means ensuring proper seating, posture, control placement, and visibility to minimise physical strain and prevent injury.

Common Ergonomic Risks

Plant operators are often exposed to:

- Prolonged sitting in awkward or static postures
- Twisting or leaning to see equipment or reach controls
- Repetitive movements without sufficient breaks
- Poor seat adjustment or lack of lumbar support



How to Reduce the Risk

1. Stretching Exercises

Stretch before and during shifts to increase blood flow and reduce stiffness

Focus on the neck, shoulders, back, and legs

Helps prevent cumulative strain injuries and improve flexibility

2. Task Rotation and Breaks

Alternate between different tasks to reduce prolonged static postures

Switch between sitting and standing tasks

Take regular breaks to reset posture and reduce fatigue

Seat Adjustment Tips

- Move the seat back, then forward until you can press the pedals fully with slightly bent knees and your back against the seat.
- Adjust seat height so hips are level with or above knees, with a clear view of the road and instruments without tilting your head.
- Ensure a small gap (about two fingers) between the back of your knees and the seat to protect circulation.

Hand-Arm Vibration Syndrome (HAVS)

HAVS is caused by regular use of vibrating tools. It can lead to numbness, tingling, loss of grip strength, and even permanent damage to hands and fingers.

Health Effects of HAVS

- **Musculoskeletal:** Carpal tunnel syndrome, osteoarthritis, joint and ligament damage.
- **Circulatory:** Blanching of fingertips (vibration white finger), numbness, and pain—can lead to gangrene in severe cases.
- **Neurological:** Permanent tingling, loss of temperature sensitivity, reduced grip strength and dexterity.



HAVS Tips

1. Use Tools the Right Way

- Only use tools you're trained to use.
- Hold tools loosely and let the tool do the work—don't grip too tightly.
- Avoid pressing too hard—extra force doesn't mean faster work.
- Keep tools sharp and well-maintained—worn tools vibrate more.

2. Limit Your Exposure

- Take regular breaks—even short one's help
- Switch tasks with others to reduce time using vibrating tools
- Use anti-vibration gloves if provided (note: they don't eliminate vibration but can help)

3. Look After Your Hands

- Keep your hands warm and dry—cold increases the risk of HAVS.
- Avoid smoking—it reduces blood flow to your fingers.
- Report any symptoms early—tingling, numbness, or pain in fingers.

4. Speak Up

- If a tool feels like it's vibrating more than usual, report it.
- If you feel symptoms, tell your supervisor or health and safety advisor, early action can prevent permanent damage.

Control	Example
Elimination	Use remote-controlled or mounted tools; design out tool use with pre-cut materials.
Reduction of Risk	Minimise drilling/prep work; select low-vibration tools; maintain equipment regularly.
Administrative Control	Limit trigger times; rotate tool use; schedule regular breaks.
Personal Protective Equipment (PPE)	Keep hands warm and dry—note anti-vibration gloves do not prevent HAVS.
Monitoring and Health Surveillance	Monitor effectiveness of controls; implement health surveillance for at-risk workers

Meet Kadija Asare, Occupational Health Nurse (Park Health & Safety)

Q: Please share a brief overview of your career to date
I started my nursing career in 2020 when I qualified. Before that I did a business management degree, but it just wasn't for me!

When I qualified in 2020 as an adult nurse I went into A&E and trauma. *Something most nurses will tell you not to do* but I thought this is my passion and I love the fast pace and not knowing what will come through the doors. I attained both my A&E and Trauma qualification which enabled me to be a competed critical A&E nurse.



I transitioned from A&E nursing to occupational health because it offered a better work-life balance, which became important as my family grew.



Q: Do you have a nickname and tell us where it came from
My nickname is 'Scotch Bonnet,' courtesy of my husband, apparently because I'm small but fiery, just like the chilli!

Q: Tell us about a skill, hidden talent or hobby that your colleagues might not know about...



Hidden Talent: I like to draw and create different outfits. I have come up with different styles that make a statement. Most of my friends call me a fashionista.



Hobby: I love everything beauty, I think it's because I did a beauty pageant (*Miss Sierra Leone*) and came 2nd, so looking at the next beauty regime gives me joy.

Q: If you could work from any location in the world, where would it be and why?

Definitely be Sierra Leone, Gambia, or Ghana. I'm proudly from both Sierra Leone and Gambia, and my husband is from Ghana, so it would feel like being surrounded by both my roots and my extended family. Plus, with free accommodation, affordable food, and vibrant culture everywhere you go, what more could I ask for? The weather's always great, the people are warm, and the energy in those places is just contagious. It would make work feel like a joy rather than a chore.



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Meet Kadija Asare,

Q: If you were Queen for a day, what would you do?

I'd dedicate my time to helping those in need, especially women and children. I'd focus on creating opportunities for education, support, and empowerment. I wouldn't want to just wear the crown for show — I'd want to leave a legacy, however small, that truly makes a difference in people's lives. To me, being a queen should be about service, not just status.



But I will also make sure everyone gets an extra day off — a bonus 'wellbeing day' to relax or do something they love. Because who doesn't love a day off.



Q: What makes you most proud?

What makes me proud is, without a doubt, God, my husband, and my daughter. My faith is my anchor — it gives me strength, wisdom, and the courage to keep pushing forward. My husband and daughter are my biggest inspirations; they remind me every day of what truly matters. Their love, support, and belief in me are what drive me to be the best I can be, both personally and professionally. Everything I achieve, I achieve with them in my heart, and that fills me with pride. They are my reason, my foundation, and my joy.

